

as Boot Activity, CPU usage, Disk I/O, Disk utilisation, etc. Armed with this indication of how well the boot process is going, you can optimise the system. Select **Trace > Optimize System**. Again, BootVis will present you with a 10-second countdown before rebooting. When the system reboots, the BootVis window will appear, indicating that BootVis is using information gained from the previous boot and the current boot to optimise the system.

When the next window appears, BootVis places the files specified in the layout.ini file in the area of contiguous disk space created during the defragmentation you did prior to running BootVis. If you have a really old installation of Windows, we'd recommend running the above procedure again or setting BootVis to repeat for two or three times.

Backup Your Files

XP comes with a free backup utility. Find it at **Start > All Programs > Accessories > System Tools > Backup**. (If it has not been installed, you can get it at <http://www.microsoft.com/windowsxp/using/setup/maintain/backupsw.mspx>.)

The Backup or Restore Wizard appears when you run the program. Click **Next**. Select the **Backup Files and Settings** Radio button. Click **Next**. Click



All information on this computer on the **What to Back Up** page, then click **Next**. Click **Choose a place to save your backup**, and select your external hard drive (or a second hard drive if you have more than one, or your CD / DVD drive) on the **Backup Type, Destination, and Name** page and click **Next**. Click **Finish** on the **Completing the Backup or Restore Wizard** page. Windows Backup will save a copy of your files to your external hard drive. If you lose some data, run the **Backup And Restore Wizard** again, and select the **Restore Files and Settings** Radio button. The Wizard explains how to proceed thereon.

We'd recommended that you back up your files every week.

Remove Unnecessary Programs

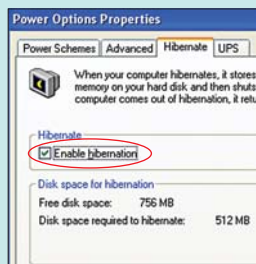
Every program installed on your computer takes up space, and some programs slow your computer down regardless of whether you use them or not. So if you installed a program you do not intend to use again, it's a good idea to uninstall it. You can do this using either

the **Add/Remove Programs** applet in the **Control Panel** or the **Uninstall** icon in the program's folder in the **Start Menu**.

You might notice leftover entries, in **Add/Remove Programs**, of programs that have already been uninstalled. You can remove these by editing the Registry. Go to **HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\SOFTWARE\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Uninstall** in the Registry, and under this key, look up the sub-keys containing the unwanted entries and delete them. You can also download and use programs such as **CCleaner** (available at www.ccleaner.com), which does the same thing and also removes all traces of uninstalled programs.

Configure Power Management

Windows XP comes with excellent power management facilities that give you great control over the amount of time that your computer components should wait to enter a low power consumption mode. This can be done using the **Power Options** applet in the **Control Panel**, where you can choose from amongst the various inbuilt power schemes. If you wish, you



Enable Hibernation from the Power Options

can also specify the amount of idle time to wait before your computer can enter the **Standby** mode.

If you can spare disk space on your OS drive equal to the amount of installed RAM, you can enable the **Hibernate** feature: in the **Hibernation** tab, check **Enable hibernation** checkbox. Go to the **Advanced** tab and select the **Hibernation** option from the drop-down list below "When I press the power button on my computer", in the **Power buttons** section. Now when you press the power button, your computer will enter the **Hibernate** state (which is faster than normal shutdown), and you can turn off the mains. When you restart your computer, it will be restored to the exact state at which you hibernated (and this is much faster than a normal XP startup). The advantage of this is that if you were working on a certain program, you can hibernate midway through it!

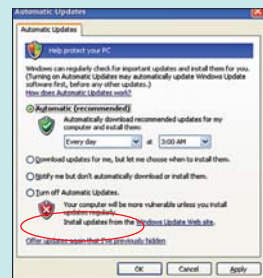
For that additional push...

The **Windows** page file is where Windows stores information about recently used programs, so as to speed

up access. By default, this file is located on the drive where XP is installed. But since this drive is already being used a lot as you work, and is prone to fragmentation, you should relocate the page file to another drive. Open **System Properties** in the **Control Panel**, select the **Advanced** tab, the **Settings** button under **Performance**, and the **Advanced** tab in the **Performance Options** that opens, and the **Change** button in the **Virtual Memory** section. You'll see a list of the drives attached to your computer, select the drive where XP is installed, select the **No paging file** button, and click **Set**. Select another drive with free space equal to at least three times the amount of installed RAM (preferably the second drive), select **System managed size**, and click **Set**. Click **OK** three times and restart Windows when prompted.

You can also make certain settings to your BIOS to quicken the boot process; enter the **CMOS** setup by pressing the appropriate hotkey (usually **[Del]**). Enable **Quick Power On Self Test (POST)**; this will cut down on a few seconds of bootup time.

Similarly, disable the option similar to "Floppy Seek on booting", so that your floppy drive will not wait to be checked for



Turn Automatic Updates on

during booting. If you don't have a floppy drive, disable the floppy controller altogether (usually located in the **Integrated Peripherals** section) and disable the floppy (usually in the first page of the **CMOS**). Similarly, you can disable communication and parallel ports, unused **SATA** controllers, on-board **LAN**, **FireWire**, and audio devices if you do not intend to use them. Finally, you should set the hard drive as the first boot device instead of the **CD-ROM**, and disable the boot ROM of your **LAN** card to further cut down on boot time.

In addition to the above, you should install critical Windows Updates regularly to fix bugs and also to update drivers and certain programs. Use the **Automatic Updates** feature to do this. Make sure this is turned on in the **Control Panel**. A good anti-virus, firewall, and anti-spyware is also a must along with regular updates (at least once a week or using the auto-update feature). Schedule these to run a thorough scan at least once a month—just so you don't forget. ☒

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